

Pro Photo Sorter — User Guide

A fully offline Windows desktop app for photographers who shoot faster than they file. (*The version you're running is shown in the Help window title bar.*)

This guide walks you through every feature. If you just want to install and start sorting, see **QUICK_START.md** first.

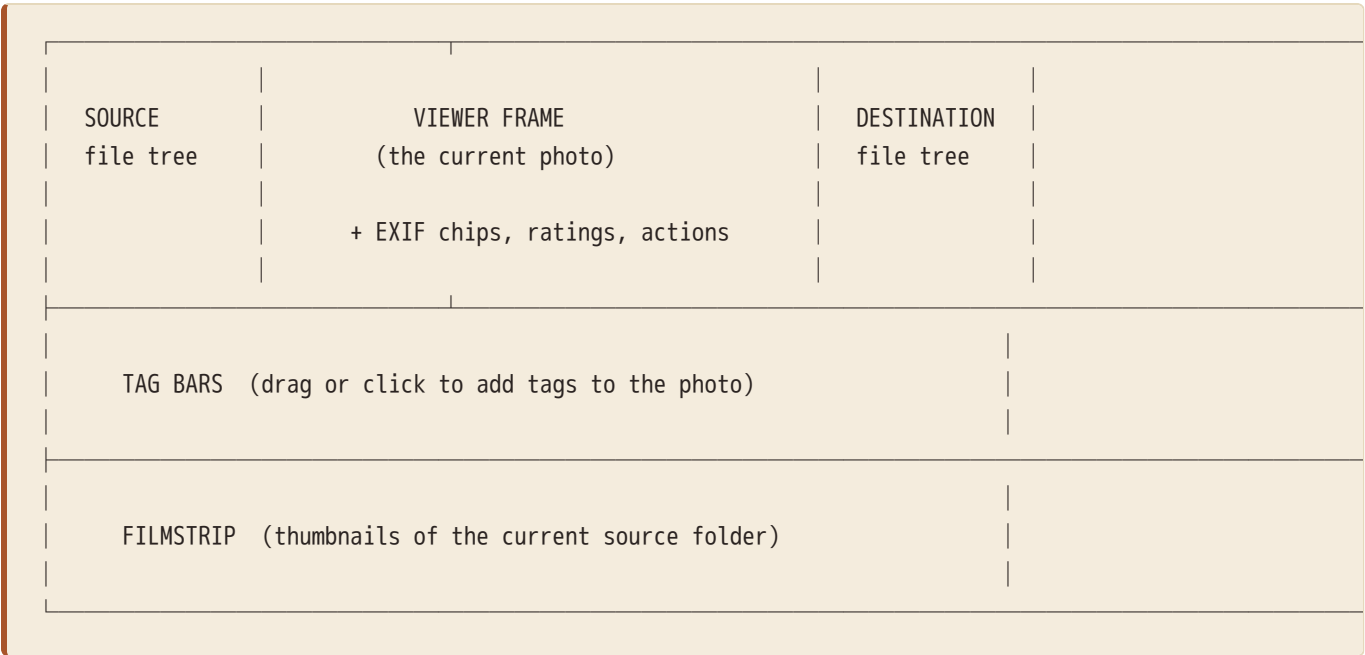
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The Big Picture

You point the app at a **source** folder (where your unsorted photos live) and a **destination** folder (where sorted photos should end up). You then click tags to build a destination path and filename. One click stores the photo, another skips or deletes it. Repeat until the source is empty.

Layout at a Glance



File Trees — Source & Destination

Both panels behave the same way:

- **Open** — pick the folder to work with. Windows remembers the last one you used per side.
- **Recent Folders** (little clock icon) — reopens folders you've used before.
- **Right-click on a destination folder** — rename, create a subfolder, or delete (empty folders only, to be safe).
- **Selection** — click any folder to make it the "current" one. The filmstrip updates for the source; the destination tree just highlights.
- **+N badges** — the destination tree shows a green pill next to any folder that received photos in your current session, so you can see at a glance where your work is going.

System folders you can't pick

Windows / Chromium blocks a handful of sensitive locations from the folder picker for security reasons. If you try one, you'll see an error message naming the block. These are:

- C:\ (the drive root itself)
- C:\Windows and its subfolders

- `C:\Program Files`, `C:\Program Files (x86)`
- Sometimes `C:\Users` root (before you drill into your own user folder)

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Pick a subfolder instead, e.g.:

- `C:\Users\YourName\Pictures` ✓
- `C:\Users\YourName\Desktop\WeddingShoot` ✓
- `D:\Photos`, `E:\Backup` — non-system drives work at any level ✓
- Any folder you created yourself ✓

If you accidentally try to pick a blocked folder and the picker gets stuck, **close the app and reopen it** — Chromium's internal picker flag doesn't reset until the app restarts.

The Filmstrip

The strip along the bottom shows thumbnails of every image in the currently selected source folder.

- **Click** a thumb to switch to it.
- **Shift+click** to select a range (for batch actions).
- **Ctrl+click** to add/remove individual thumbs from the batch selection.
- **Star overlay** — quick stars are drawn on top of thumbs you've rated.
- **Autoscroll** — the current thumb always scrolls into view.
- **Arrow keys** — Left / Right walk through the filmstrip.

Tag Packs & Tags

Tag Packs are named collections of tags (icons + text). Think of them as category groups: "Wedding", "Wildlife", "Real Estate", etc.

Tags live inside packs and have:

- an **icon** (from Lucide's icon library — hundreds available)
- a **label** you type in
- a color chip you pick

Two tag bars sit between the viewer and the filmstrip:

- **Folders bar** — tags dropped here build the destination *folder path*. Example: `Wedding / Ceremony / Bride` → files land in `Wedding\Ceremony\Bride\...`
- **Tags bar** — tags dropped here are appended to the *filename*. Example: filename becomes `IMG_0421_bride_smiling.jpg`.

Managing Tag Packs

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Click the **Tags** button in the toolbar to open the Tag Manager:

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- **Add pack / Rename pack / Delete pack**
- **Add tag** inside either list (Folder or Filename), choose icon and label
- **Paste...** button on each list — paste one label per line and click "Add all" to bulk-create tags in seconds
- **Right-click a tag** in the palette bar to rename or delete inline
- **Drag a tag** between the Folder and Filename sections in Tag Manager to reassign it
- **Drag a tag** between packs (in the palette bars) to reorganize
- **Import pack** (`.pps-tagpack.json`) or **Export pack** to share as JSON
- **Import text list** (`.pps-taglist.txt`) — plain-text format below, one or more packs per file
- **Export as text** — turns any pack into a shareable `.pps-taglist.txt`
- **Export bundle** (`.zip`) to package every pack in one archive

Text-list format (`.pps-taglist.txt`)

Author packs in Notepad and share them as `.txt` . Format:

```
# Wedding          ← pack name, line starts with #
Ceremony           ← folder tags, one per line
Reception
Portraits

Bride              ← BLANK line → filename tags start here
Groom
First-Kiss

# Wildlife          ← another # starts the next pack
Mammals
Birds
Reptiles

Portrait
Action
Flying

// lines that start with // are comments and get ignored
```

Every imported tag gets the default `Tag` icon — you can promote any of them to a specific Lucide icon in the Tag Manager later.

Starter packs (`landscape` , `wedding` , `portrait` , `wildlife` , `sports` , `real-estate`) live in `starter-packs/` inside the app folder. You can also import them via the Tag Manager.

Sorting a Photo

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The workflow, once you have source, destination, and a tag pack loaded:

1. Click a thumb (or press an arrow key) to select the photo.
2. Drag tags into the **Folders bar** to shape its destination path.
3. Drag tags into the **Tags bar** to shape its filename.
4. Click **Store** — the photo is *copied* into the built path and the filmstrip auto-advances.
5. Repeat.

Alternative actions:

- **Move** — same as Store but *deletes* the source file after copy.
- **Skip** — advance without storing.
- **Delete** — remove the source file entirely.

Nothing is destroyed without your click. Store never touches the source.

Star Ratings

Every photo can carry a 0–5 star rating.

- Set stars from the toolbar or by pressing **0** – **5**.
- Stars persist across sessions.
- Star filters live in the Search modal.
- Use **Auto-Rate** in the toolbar to run a focus/exposure heuristic that guesses a rating for the current photo (or your batch selection).

Full-Screen Cull Mode

Click **Cull** in the toolbar. This gives you:

- Big preview, no chrome
- Left/Right to walk, **1** – **5** to rate, **Delete** to trash
- Great for a quick first-pass rate-and-reject sweep

Press **Esc** to return to the main layout.

Image Editor

Click **Edit** on the current photo. Non-destructive tweaks:

- Crop with a movable box, ratio-locked or free

- Exposure, contrast, saturation, temperature, tint
- Rotate & flip
- Auto-Tone (analyzes the histogram and adjusts)
- Save the edited version alongside the original with a `_edit` suffix

Watermarks

The watermark system lives inside the toolbar and Batch modal.

- Set the watermark **text**, **font**, **position** (drag it on the preview), **scale**, **opacity**, and **Light/Dark** style.
- Toggle watermark **for this photo only** with the quick pill in the toolbar or right-click the viewer.
- Toggle watermark **for the whole batch** with the batch modal switch.

Watermarks are applied at export time — the source file is never changed.

Resize to Print Size

Aspect-ratio store buttons (in the toolbar): **4×6**, **5×7**, **8×10**, **11×14**. Click one and a **Resize Crop Preview** modal opens:

- Preview the exact print crop (letterboxed or filled)
- Drag the crop box around the photo to control what's kept
- Pick output DPI (default 300 DPI)
- Click **Store** — a cropped + resized copy lands in the destination

Templates and tags are inherited, so the file still routes correctly.

Batch Actions

Select multiple thumbs (Shift-click or Ctrl-click), then click **Batch** in the toolbar. From there:

- Store / Move / Delete / Skip the whole selection
- Apply a watermark to the batch
- Apply an aspect-ratio resize to the batch
- Batch-rename via a template (`{date}_{location}_{n}` etc.)

Search

Click **Search** in the toolbar. Filters include:

- Filename substring

- Star rating range
- Date range (from EXIF)
- ISO / focal length / aperture ranges
- Camera model

Results appear in a scrollable list; click any hit to jump to that photo.

The search has a **Stop & Load Partial** button for big folders — if you're already looking at the shot you wanted, you don't have to wait for the full scan to finish.

Recent Folders

Next to the **Open** button on both panels, a little dropdown remembers up to five recent folders per side. Chrome/Electron re-verifies read/write permission each time you reopen.

Drive & Space Info

Click the  **Drives** button next to the Open button on either panel to see a live snapshot of every drive on the system:

- Drive letter and volume label
- Total capacity
- Free space
- Used space with a bar chart

At the bottom of both panels, a small "System free" chip shows the total free space across all drives so you know at a glance when it's time to plug in another disk. This information requires the desktop (Electron) build to be running — in a plain browser, the chip is hidden.

Settings

The gear icon opens Settings:

- **Theme** — Light / Dark
- **Filename template** — how automatic filenames are built
- **Star rating hotkeys** — enable/disable  —  shortcuts
- **Default tag packs** for the two bars
- **Auto-Tone toggle** for the Edit modal

Keyboard Shortcuts

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Key	Action
← / →	Previous / next photo
Space	Store the current photo
M	Move (Store + delete source)
Del	Delete the current photo
S	Skip
0 — 5	Star rating
Ctrl+F	Open Search
Ctrl+B	Open Batch modal
Ctrl+E	Open Image Editor
Ctrl+Shift+W	Toggle watermark for this photo
F1 / ?	Toggle this Help window
Esc	Close any modal / exit Cull Mode

Reporting Bugs

The bottom-right corner of the Destination panel shows the version and build date, e.g. `v1.0.0 · 2026-02-15`.

Please include this string in any bug report so we know exactly which build you're on.

Screenshots, the source folder path, and the exact steps to reproduce are gold — the more you share, the faster the fix.